

Coastal field guide

Shorebirds of the Derwent estuary · A pocket companion for volunteer surveyors

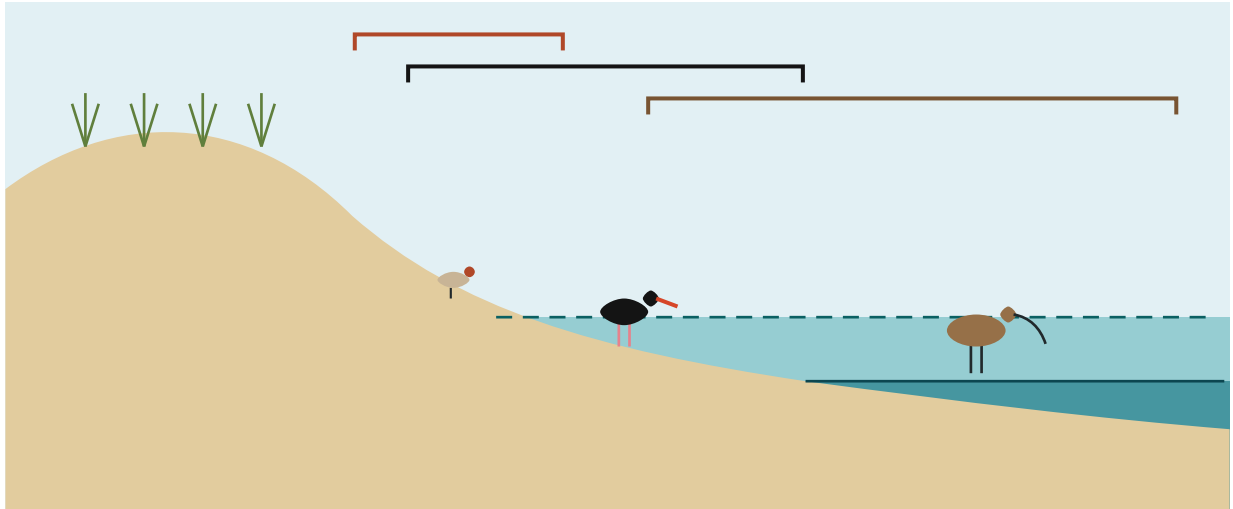


Figure 1. From dune to channel: feeding zones for the oystercatcher (black), the red-capped plover (rust), and the curlew (brown)

Reading the estuary

Shorebirds follow the tide. Most feed on the **falling** tide, when fresh mud is exposed, and roost above the high-tide line in the two hours either side of high water. Plan counts around the roost: birds are packed together and easy to tally. The three species described in Species accounts between them use every zone in Figure 1.

- **Dune and upper beach:** nesting plovers from August to January. Keep to the wet sand.
- **Sand flats:** oystercatchers probing for pipis and worms.
- **Soft mud and shallows:** curlews and godwits working the channel edge.

Roost counts: from two hours before to one hour after high tide.

Feeding counts: on the falling tide, three to five hours after high water.

Avoid days with wind above 25 km/h; birds hunker down and are hard to see.

Species accounts

Each plate below is drawn to the same scale, so relative size is a first clue. Compare bill shape next: it tells you how, and where, a bird feeds.

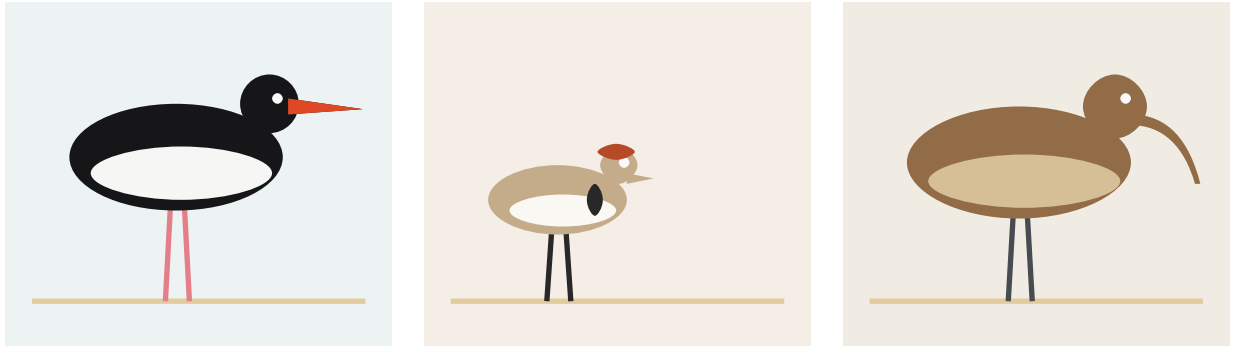


Figure 2. Plates to scale: pied oystercatcher, red-capped plover, and Far Eastern curlew

Pied oystercatcher

A bold black-and-white wader that feeds in pairs across the open flats. Its all-black cousin, the sooty oystercatcher, prefers rocky shores. Compare the curlew, which shares the flats but probes deeper.

- **Size:** 42 to 50 cm; the largest black-and-white bird on the flats.
- **Field marks:** long straight orange-red bill, red eye-ring, pink legs.
- **Call:** a loud, piping “kleep kleep” when disturbed.

Red-capped plover

A tiny, fast-running plover that nests in a bare scrape on the upper beach. Eggs and chicks are almost invisible against the sand, so follow the field etiquette closely during the nesting season.

- **Size:** 14 to 16 cm; smaller than a sparrow.
- **Field marks:** pale grey-brown above, white below; adult males have a rufous cap and a dark bar across the shoulder.
- **Call:** a thin, sharp “tik” as it runs ahead of you.

Far Eastern curlew

The world's largest shorebird, and an endangered migrant that flies from breeding grounds in Siberia each September. It is wary: record it from a distance and never approach a roost. Unlike the oystercatcher, it feeds alone.

- **Size:** 53 to 66 cm; the bill alone can reach 18 cm.
- **Field marks:** streaked brown all over, with a very long down-curved bill.
- **Call:** a mournful, rising “cur-lee” carried across the water.

Running a survey

Counts are held on the second Sunday of each month, starting one hour before high tide. Enter your results in the national database with the site code DERW-04, or send your sheet to the survey coordinator.

1. Note the time, the tide height, the weather, and any disturbance.
2. Scan the roost from one end to the other, counting in blocks of ten:
 - count the large species first,
 - then sweep again for the small ones.
3. Record colour-banded birds with the band colours, top to bottom, left leg first.
4. Enter a zero for every species you looked for and did not find.

Stay at least 50 m from roosting and nesting birds.

Keep dogs on a lead; dogs are banned from the spit all year.

If birds take flight or call in alarm, you are too close.

Survey checklist

The species most often recorded on the estuary. Status follows the national threatened species list; see the Atlas of Living Australia for maps and records.

Table 1. Shorebirds recorded on the estuary, with a column for your count

Species	Scientific name	Season	Status	Count
Pied oystercatcher	<i>Haematopus longirostris</i>	All year	Resident	—
Sooty oystercatcher	<i>Haematopus fuliginosus</i>	All year	Resident	—
Red-capped plover	<i>Charadrius ruficapillus</i>	All year	Resident	—
Hooded plover	<i>Thinornis cucullatus</i>	All year	Vulnerable	—
Masked lapwing	<i>Vanellus miles</i>	All year	Resident	—
Far Eastern curlew	<i>Numenius madagascariensis</i>	Sep to Apr	Endangered	—
Bar-tailed godwit	<i>Limosa lapponica</i>	Sep to Apr	Vulnerable	—
Red-necked stint	<i>Calidris ruficollis</i>	Sep to Apr	Migrant	—
Double-banded plover	<i>Charadrius bicinctus</i>	Mar to Aug	Migrant	—